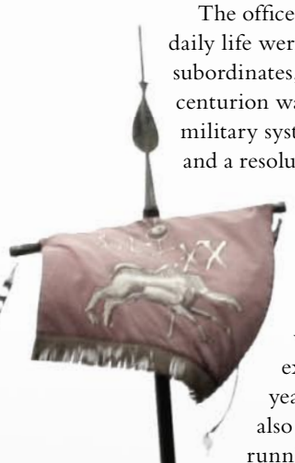
around his neck, the legionary was integrated into a tight-knit hierarchical organization. At the lowest level, he belonged to a *contubernium*, a group of eight men who shared rooms in barracks and messed together. Ten of these *contubernia* formed a century, commanded by a centurion; six centuries made a cohort and ten cohorts a legion. Each legion had its carefully preserved traditions and its symbols, creating a sense of identity for its soldiers, who would regard other legions than their own with rivalry or contempt.

The officers who regulated the legionary's daily life were the centurion and his various subordinates, known as *principales*. The centurion was a key figure in the Roman military system, a repository of experience and a resolute source of leadership at the level where it counted most. At least some, and possibly most, centurions had worked their way up through the ranks, although a legionary who aspired to this status could expect first to endure at least 15 years of military service. He would also need to be literate, for the running of any part of the Roman army generated large quantities of documents for official records. Above the centurion level, officers were members of the ruling classes appointed through the influence of powerful patrons.



Square flag (*vexillum*) bearing the legion's symbol, which marked the position of the commander on the battlefield



Frontier force
The bulk of the Roman army was stationed along the Empire's frontiers, although the major cities of the eastern Mediterranean also came under the legion's watchful eye. Only short stretches of frontier were fortified.

TRAINING AND WORKING

Most legionaries were posted to some remote area near the frontiers of the Empire, or to one of the cities of the eastern Mediterranean, such as Jerusalem, that were considered sufficiently unreliable to require a strong military presence. Since warfare tended to be sporadic, they were likely to spend the majority of their time in the army on peacetime garrison duties in a barracks. Keeping militarily up to scratch under these circumstances was inevitably a challenge.

The training of a legionary, which continued throughout his service, focused on three goals: physical fitness and endurance; the skilled use of weaponry; and disciplined action as part of a unit. Men were taken out on forced marches of 30–50km (20–30 miles) with heavy packs and full equipment. They engaged in mock combat, from one-on-one fighting to elaborate exercises involving entire units. Naturally, they were taught to march in step and they carried out formation drills in preparation for close-order combat.

Apart from the routine of training, drill, guard duties, and fatigues, the legionaries fulfilled an essential everyday function in patrolling and policing areas prone to lawlessness, rebellion, or incursions by armed groups from across the border. They were also responsible for large-scale building work, carrying out both civilian and military projects, including the construction of roads, fortresses, and aqueducts. Hadrian's Wall in northern England is a notable example of a legionary-built structure, each section of the wall being completed by a different century. Legions also had an important role as manufacturers, their workshops supplying many of the army's material needs, from pottery to weaponry.



Roman battle order
Roman legionaries advanced on their enemies with swords drawn and shields raised. Flags and other standards were important symbols of Roman power and served as rallying points for the cohorts and centuries within the legion.